

Nazi Germany found a chance to try out its aircraft and tactics when a civil war broke out in Spain in 1936. Right-wing “Nationalist” Spanish officers, who had failed to overthrow the country’s left-wing Republican government in an insurrection, asked for the Nazis’ help to mount a sustained military campaign. The Luftwaffe immediately sent a score of Ju 52 transport aircraft to airlift soldiers from Spanish Morocco to Nationalist-controlled Seville in southern Spain. This was an unprecedented operation – the movement by air of a major military force. Between July and October 1936, some 20,000 soldiers with their equipment, including artillery, were airlifted into Seville, enabling the Nationalists to take the offensive.

Aerial artillery

While Nazi Germany and Fascist Italy provided air support for the Nationalists, the Soviet Union sent pilots and aircraft to fight for the Republican side. By the end of 1936, Soviet I-15 and I-16 fighters had won air superiority and were able to inflict serious damage on ground forces, notably with the destruction of an Italian motorized column at Guadalajara in March 1937. The Luftwaffe responded by sending in the Condor

Legion, a force of around 100 of its latest aircraft and best-trained pilots, with Colonel Wolfram von Richthofen, cousin of the Red Baron, as its chief of staff. Wherever the Messerschmitt Bf 109s appeared, Soviet aircraft were driven from the skies. With air superiority assured, the Condor Legion experimented with close air support, acting as “aerial artillery” to prepare the way for ground offensives, and interdiction – air attacks on enemy reserve troops and communications behind the front line. This use of air power proved decisive, allowing the Nationalists to achieve victory by 1939.

While the Luftwaffe was drawing invaluable insights and accurate conclusions from the actual experience of combined-arms operations, the attention of the world at large was fixed upon a single issue: the terror-bombing of civilians. This



TERROR-BOMBING

A Spanish Republican propaganda poster makes a powerful attack on the German bombing of Guernica in 1937: “This is the health/salute [Heil] they bring.”

was somewhat peripheral to air operations in the civil war but central to the fears and anxieties of the citizens of London, Paris, and even New York, who could not help but see events in Spain as prefiguring their own possible future fate. Both sides in the Spanish conflict at times bombed enemy-held towns and cities, but the

German and Italian air forces had far more opportunity to do so and caused the most loss of life. Apart from the devastation of the small Basque town of Guernica in April 1937, Republican-held Madrid came under intermittent aerial bombardment from 1936 onward, and the Catalan city of Barcelona was heavily bombed by the Italians for three days in March 1938, killing around 1,300 people.

Civilian reaction

There was no question that air attack frightened people. Esmond Romilly, a British volunteer fighting with the Republican International Brigades, described being trapped in a subway station during an air raid in Madrid: “A panic-stricken crowd made it impossible to move... women screamed and on the steps men were fighting to get into the shelter.” US military attaché Stephen O. Fuqua, in Barcelona during the March 1938 raids, reported that economic and industrial life was “completely paralyzed” and “semipanic permeated every form of city life.” Fuqua graphically described civilians suddenly blown to pieces while sitting on buses or at the tables of sidewalk cafes – afterward he saw the cafe waiters “sweeping up the human bits into containers.”

Yet for all this horror, it was evident that civilians soon learned to cope psychologically with the threat of bombing. The Condor Legion’s assessment of the effect of “destructive bombardments without clear military targets,”

WATCHFUL CIVILIANS

Civilians in the Republican port of Bilbao, in Spain’s Basque country, walk in fear as aircraft appear overhead. In April 1937 Bilbao was bombed by warplanes from the German Condor Legion and the Italian Aviazione Legionaria, supporting the Nationalist side in the Spanish Civil War.

